Beyond The Screen: Crafting a purposeful digital presence

Project Report

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Platform-VITyarthi

1. Introduction

The project navigates us our roles and responsibilities as a “Student Digital Ambassador”. The aim is to create a overarching portfolio that demonstrates prowess in professional digital communication , online safety , and technical alliance. The project is organized within a Github repository . chronicling five specific modules ranging from infographic blueprint to cybercrime cognizance.

2.Problem Statement

In the current academic and professional landscape, technical skills alone are insufficient.Pupils often face a dearth of professional “digital footprint” and may be unknown to the nuances of professional email behaviour or the specific mechanics of modern cyber threats like UPI fraud.

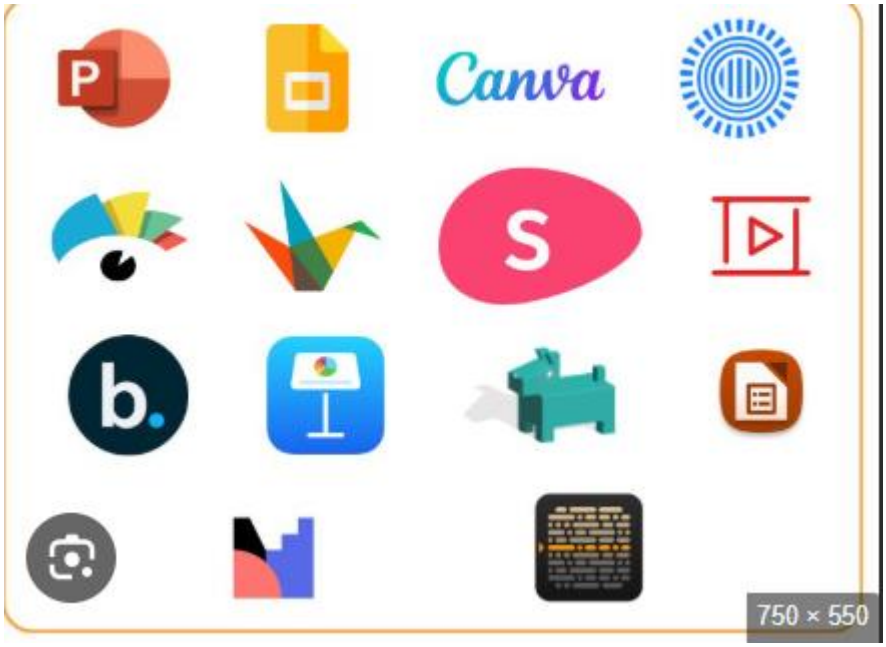
Introduction

When I first heard the term 'Digital Literacy', I assumed it just meant knowing how to use a smartphone or browse the internet. But this project quickly proved me wrong. Digital literacy is something much broader — it covers everything from building a professional online presence to recognising a phishing email before it tricks you.

This project was structured around a scenario: I was selected as a Student Digital Ambassador, and my responsibility was to guide my batchmates through the digital world. Across five tasks, I explored tools for visual communication, built my student portfolio on professional platforms, practised on coding sites, drafted formal emails, and researched cybercrime cases specific to college students in India.

Working through these tasks felt less like an academic exercise and more like an actual orientation into digital life — the kind of orientation most of us never received. By the end, I had a GitHub repository, active profiles on multiple platforms, and a clearer understanding of both the opportunities and the risks that come with living online. This report documents everything I did, what I learned, and a few things I will genuinely do differently going forward.

Task 1 Follow Up



Task 1 – Digital Literacy Awareness Infographic

Overview

For this task, I was asked to create a one-page visual that would help my batchmates understand what digital literacy means and why it matters. I chose Canva because it is free, browser-based, and has a large library of templates that look polished even without any prior design experience. Making it a truly user-friendly interface.

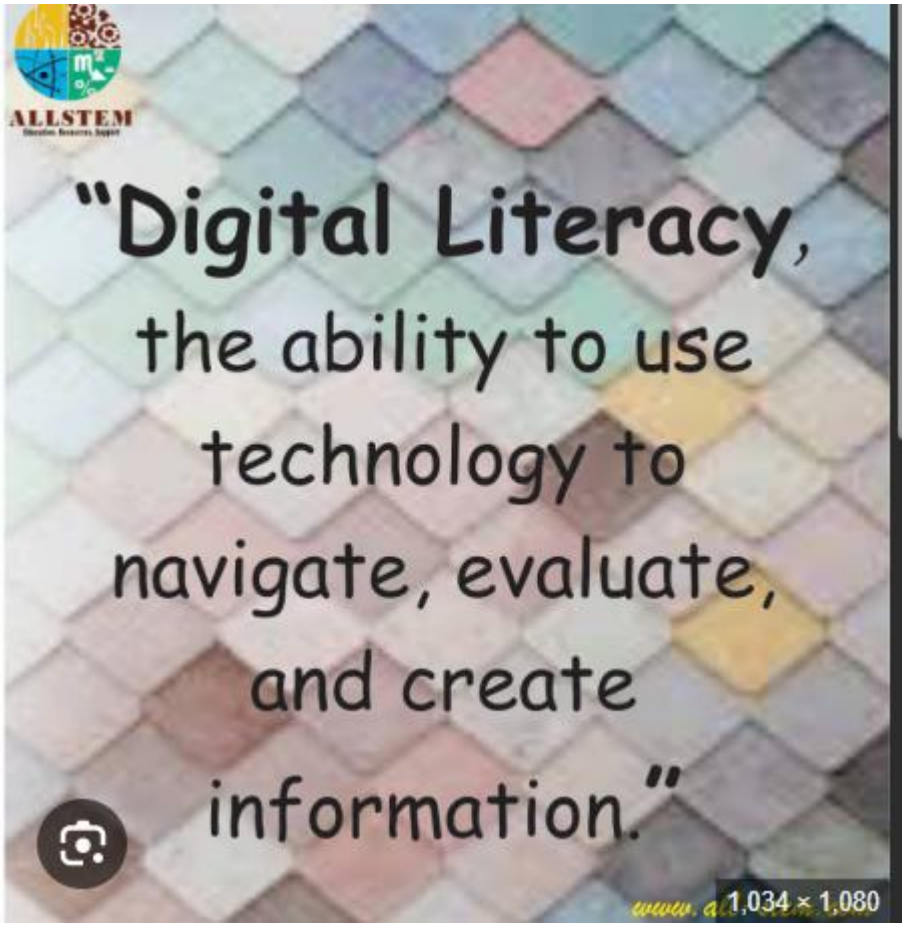
Reflection

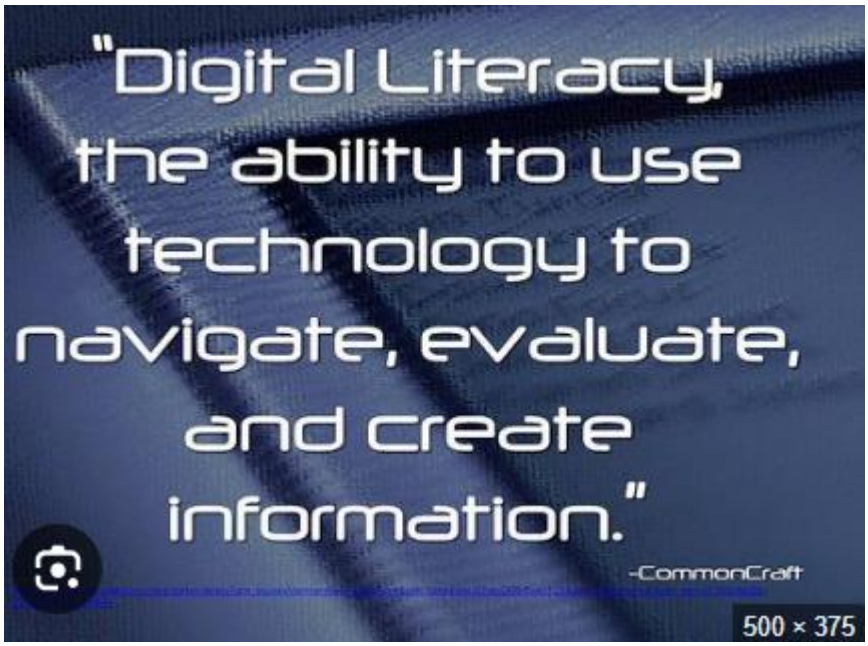
I used Canva to design my infographic and chose a clean, colour-blocked layout with icons. The design covers three main areas: Like what digital literacy actually is (the ability to find, evaluate, and communicate information online) or the definition of digtal literacy , safe internet practices such as not sharing passwords and identifying fake websites(how they are very important in today”s world), and building a professional online presence using platforms like LinkedIn and GitHub, making our digtal profile , unlocking a millions of opportunities in the process meanwhile.

Also I had arranged the content in three columns — each with a short heading, a small icon, and two or three bullet points — so it would be easy to read at a glance. I kept the colour palette limited to blue and white so it would print clearly in black-and-white too, which is practical for sharing in class and is also explainable in simple language by anybody.

Of all the pars I found most interesting was researching about what 'digital literacy' actually includes. I had assumed it was mostly about technical skills, and different platforms , their uses and how they can be integrated in our workflow ,but I learned that it also covers critical thinking — for example, checking whether a source is credible before sharing it.

One of The most difficult part of the project was fitting everything into a single page without it looking cluttered. I had to cut a lot of content I initially wanted to include, which taught me that good design is as much about what you leave out as what you put in.


ALLSTEM
"Digital Literacy,
the ability to use
technology to
navigate, evaluate,
and create
information."
1,034 × 1,080


"Digital Literacy,
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-CommonCraft
500 × 375

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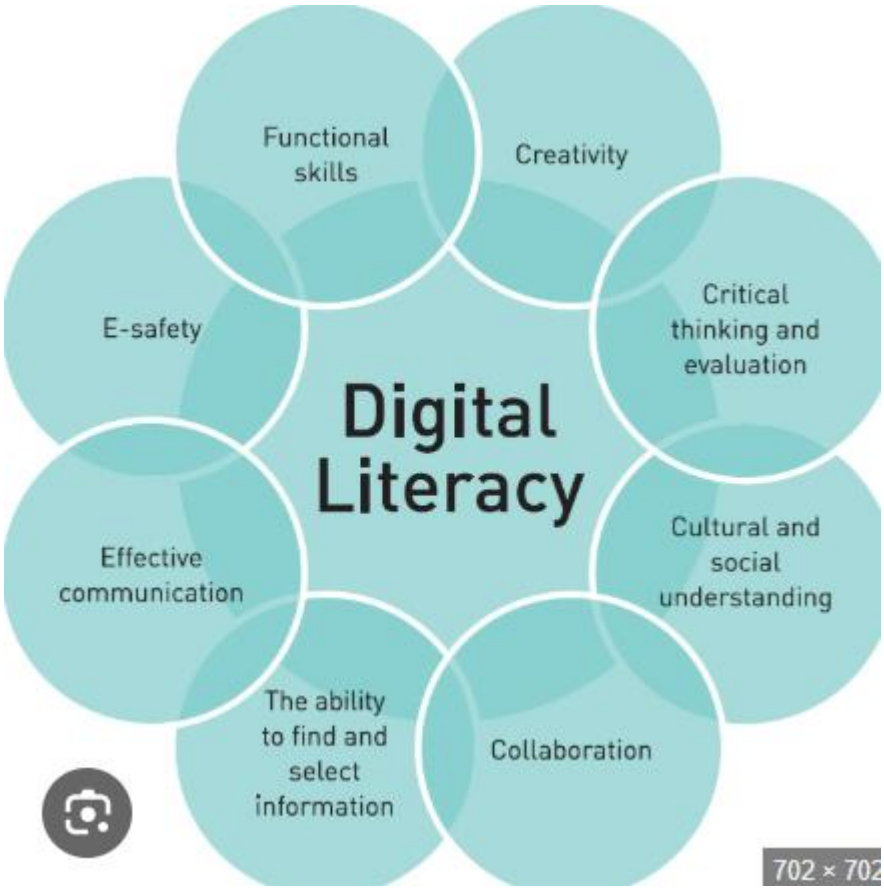

Digital Literacy
Functional skills
Creativity
Critical thinking and evaluation
Cultural and social understanding
Collaboration
The ability to find and select information
Effective communication
E-safety
702 × 702

Task 2 Follow Up

Task 2 – Student Digital Portfolio

Overview

For this task, I had to set up accounts on three platforms: GitHub, LinkedIn, and Kaggle. We can think of a student's digital profile as their personal "living" brand. It"s much more than just an online version of a report card , we can think of it as a curated space that tells the story of who they are , how they think , and what they are capable of achieving Each of them serves a different purpose in a student's academic and professional life, and together they form the foundation of a digital presence that will grow alongside my career

In short it's the shift from being a number on a spreadsheet to being a multi-dimensional person with a unique set of talents.

Reflection

History is evident In the old days of hiring, we handed over a resume, talked a big game in an interview, and hoped the employer took your word for it. But in today's world—especially in tech—that "trust me" approach is dead. We've moved into the era of the digital handshake, and for most students and creators, that handshake happens on GitHub.

If a resume is a list of promises, a GitHub profile is a list of receipts. It is the difference between saying "I know how to build a house" and actually showing someone ho the house is built brick-by-brick and step-by-step ,

GitHub is the platform where developers and computer science students store and share their code. I created a profile README — a special file that appears on your GitHub profile page — and filled it with my name, branch, current year, and a short line about what I hope to learn during my four years here. Even though I have not written any real code yet, having an active GitHub account from the first year means I can start building a visible track record early.

Your LinkedIn profile is your digital reputation. In a world where everyone is a stranger, it provides the context that makes people trust you. It's about building a bridge between where you are now (a student) and where you want to be (a professional).

We can Think of LinkedIn not as a digital filing cabinet for your resume, but as the 24/7 lobby of your professional life. It’s the only place where a recruiter, a future co-founder, or a mentor can "meet" you before you even know they exist . somewhere.. LinkedIn is where professionals share their experience, education, and achievements. I filled in my education section with my degree, VIT Bhopal University, and my expected graduation year. I plan to update it with internships, projects, and skills as I progress. By the time I am in my final year, I want my LinkedIn to speak for itself.

Kaggle is a data science and machine learning community. I set up my profile there even though I am just beginning to learn these topics. My plan is to start with beginner datasets and guided notebooks in my second year, then attempt real competitions in the third and fourth year. Over the next four years, these three platforms will work together — GitHub to show my code, LinkedIn to show my professional growth, and e to show my analytical side.

"Action" Platforms: Places Where Talk is Cheap

Stack Overflow: The Technical "Combat" Zone

Think of Stack Overflow as the gladiator arena of the internet. It’s where developers go when their code is screaming, their servers are melting, and they’ve got ten minutes to fix a bug before the "villain" (a crashed system) wins.

We aren't just answering questions; you’re a digital first-responder. When you step into a thread and solve a problem that’s been haunting someone for three days, you aren't just a "student." You’re the expert who swooped in to save the mission.

It’s about the clutch save. A recruiter doesn't just see a high score; they see someone who can walk into a room full of panic and provide the exact solution needed to keep the project alive.

kaggle

Task 3 Follow up

Task 3 – Coding and Collaboration Platforms

Overview

This task had two parts. For Part A, I created an account on HackerRank and completed a beginner-level coding challenge. For Part B, I built a Digital Literacy Awareness Quiz using Google Forms, which I linked to a Google Sheet for collecting responses.

The rain is lashing against the window, a rhythmic percussion to the frantic clicking of a mechanical keyboard. You've got three minutes before the server crashes, and the only thing standing between you and digital oblivion is a single, missing semicolon. This isn't just a job; it's a high-stakes heist where the vault is a codebase and the prize is a seamless user experience. In this world, coding platforms are your training grounds, your weapons lockers, and your digital colosseums.

What are Coding Platforms?

Think of a coding platform as a high-tech gym for your brain. They are online environments where you can write, test, and debug code without needing to set up a complex local environment. From Competitive Programming sites like Codeforces to Learning Hubs like LeetCode or HackerRank, these platforms provide the "puzzles" that sharpen your blade.

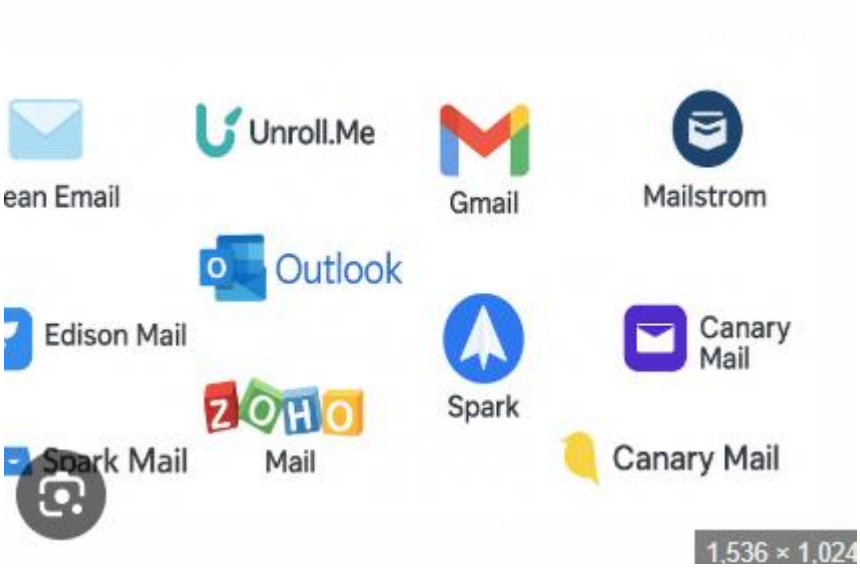
Reflection

On HackerRank, I attempted the 'Solve Me First' challenge, which is a simple addition problem designed to introduce new users to the platform. It was not difficult, but the process of reading the problem statement, understanding the expected input and output format, and submitting a solution was genuinely useful — it showed me what structured programming challenges look like in practice. HackerRank also has learning tracks for specific languages and skills, which I plan to use once I start my programming courses properly.

For the Google Form, I created a five-question Digital Literacy Awareness Quiz. The questions covered: the definition of digital literacy, one example of a safe online practice, a multiple choice question on email etiquette, a short answer question asking what the respondent would do if they received a suspicious link, and one question on identifying a phishing email. I connected the form to a Google Sheet, which automatically records every response in a table.

Both tools will be genuinely useful in my academics. HackerRank will help me practise problem-solving between semesters. Google Forms and Sheets are practical for collecting survey data in projects, organising study group sign-ups, and even peer feedback forms — things I can see myself using throughout my four years here.

Task 4 Follow Up



Task 4 – Professional Email and Etiquette

Overview

This task required me to write two professional emails — one to a professor and one to an internship coordinator — and to create a social media Do's and Don'ts checklist for college students.

Email 1 – Extension Request to Professor

Subject: Request for Submission Deadline Extension – [Assignment Name]

Dear Professor [Last Name],

I hope this message finds you well. I am writing to respectfully request a short extension on the deadline for [Assignment Name], which is currently due on [Date].

Over the past few days, I have been dealing with [brief, honest reason — e.g. a health issue / a family matter / an unexpected conflict with another submission]. I have already completed a significant portion of the work and am committed to submitting the best possible output. I am requesting an extension of [number] days, until [New Date], if that is acceptable.

I understand this is an inconvenience and I sincerely apologise for not reaching out sooner. I am happy to share my progress so far if that would be helpful.

Thank you very much for your time and consideration.

Warm regards,
[Your Name]
[Reg. No. | Branch | Year]

Email 2 – Internship Enquiry to Company

Subject: Internship Application – Summer 2025 – [Branch/Domain]

Dear [Mr./Ms. Last Name / Hiring Team],

I am [Your Name], a first-year B.Tech student in [Branch] at VIT Bhopal University, and I am writing to express my interest in a summer internship opportunity at [Company Name].

I am eager to gain practical exposure in [relevant domain — e.g. software development / data analytics] and your organisation's work in [mention something specific about the company] genuinely aligns with what I hope to learn. Though I am early in my academic journey, I am a quick learner and highly motivated to contribute.

I would be grateful for the opportunity to discuss any available openings or to be considered for future intake. I have attached my academic profile for your reference.

Thank you for taking the time to read this. I look forward to hearing from you.

Yours sincerely,
[Your Name]
[Contact | LinkedIn Profile | GitHub Profile]

Reflection – Poor Digital Communication Scenario

A situation that comes to mind is one I read about online: a student sent a complaint about a professor to a group chat, intending it only for one friend — but accidentally sent it to the entire class group, which also included the professor. The fallout was significant: the student faced formal disciplinary action, and the working relationship with that professor became permanently strained.

What could have been done differently? The most obvious answer is to simply use a private chat or call instead of a group message for anything sensitive. But beyond that, it is worth pausing before sending any message that involves frustration or criticism — what you write online leaves a record, and tone is very easy to misread. A quick check

of who is in a group before sending can prevent situations like this entirely. This task made me much more conscious of double-checking recipients before hitting send.

Task 5 Follow Up

Task 5 – Cybercrime Awareness Case Study

Overview

For this task, I chose to research UPI and online payment fraud, specifically targeting college students. I then created a prevention checklist with safety tips relevant to the Indian context.

Case Study – UPI Payment Fraud Targeting Students

UPI payment fraud is one of the most rapidly growing forms of cybercrime in India, and college students are a particularly common target. The crime typically begins when a fraudster contacts a student — often via WhatsApp, Instagram DM, or a fake online marketplace — posing as a buyer or a fellow student offering a deal.

In the most common version: the fraudster says they want to pay the student for a second-hand item (a book, a laptop, anything listed on OLX). They send a QR code or a 'payment request' link, telling the student to 'scan it to receive money.' The student, unfamiliar with the fact that scanning a payment request deducts money rather than adding it, scans the code and immediately loses the amount. By the time the victim realises what has happened, the scammer has blocked them and disappeared.

Students from smaller cities or those new to UPI apps are especially vulnerable. The consequences range from losing a few hundred rupees to losing thousands — money that students can rarely afford to lose. The psychological impact is also significant; victims often feel embarrassed and are reluctant to report the incident.

Reflection

What surprised me most while researching this topic was just how straightforward and low-tech these scams actually are. I had assumed cybercrime involved complicated hacking — but many of the most effective frauds rely on nothing more than social engineering: creating a sense of urgency, exploiting a student's unfamiliarity with how payment apps work, and building just enough fake trust to get someone to act quickly without thinking.

The one habit I will personally change as a result of this research is this: I will never scan a QR code or click a payment link from anyone I do not know personally, no matter how convincing the reason sounds. I also plan to share the National Cyber Crime Helpline number — 1930 — with my family, because it was genuinely news to me that such a resource exists and is available around the clock.

Conclusion

This project turned out to be more practical than I expected. Going in, I thought it would be mostly theoretical — read about digital tools, write about them, submit. What actually happened was different: I set up accounts that I will keep using, drafted emails that follow formats I will refer back to, and learned about cybercrimes that are genuinely happening to people my age in India right now.

The biggest takeaway for me is that your digital presence starts building from day one of college — whether or not you pay attention to it. A GitHub profile with nothing in it still exists. An email with a poor subject line still gets read (or ignored) by a professor. A careless message in a group chat still has consequences. This project gave me the tools and the awareness to be more intentional about all of that from here on.